Son of a farmer from Bandipora, Ishfaq Hussain Kawa gained prominence in the Valley after his songs went viral on the internet in 2017. Though he has no clear choice between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, he wants a PM who does not look at issues through the prism of religion. And that's why Kawa is not happy with the incumbent BJP-led government,

Top 3 demands: Fulfil basic needs of *bijli, sadak, paani*; end harassment of citizens; welfare of all

What will influence his vote: Unemployment, communal tensions, abrogation of Article 370

"We are witnessing too much communal tensions. The new government should work towards ending the conflict between Muslims and Hindus"

under which, he feels, communal tensions have escalated. "The new government," he says, "should work towards ending the conflict between Muslims and Hindus." Kawa also finds the Modi regime's performance wanting when it comes to job creation. Unemployment is the issue that influenced his choice of candidate when he voted for the first time. And it's on his mind yet again. "My vote will go to the party that addresses unemployment, drug addiction and security issues," he says, adding that the abrogation of Article 370 snatched the exclusive rights of locals to jobs. ■

-Moazum Mohammad

CHISELLING CHANGE

A graduate from the Government College of Art and Craft in Kolkata, Sirsha Acharya likes to refer to himself as a nationalist. His paintings have often been shared on social media by the likes of Union

"The construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya has strengthened an entire community which was losing its identity"

minister Smriti Irani, filmmaker Vivek Agnihotri and Lok Sabha member and BJP's former state unit chief Dilip Ghosh. A fan of external affairs minister S. Jaishankar, he believes that India has reclaimed its global supremacy in recent years. Currently residing in a rented flat in Kolkata, Acharya will be travelling to Baharampur, from where he hails, to vote. This seat is represented by Congress veteran Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury since 1999. But Acharya, whose father works for a car manufacturer and mother is a homemaker, feels that Chowdhury has "done nothing" for his constituency. Among other issues, his vote will be for a Uniform Civil Code and against the appeasement of minorities. The construction of the Ram temple will also influence his choice. However, the Congress's promise of the 'Right to Apprenticeship' and government jobs sounds "encouraging" to him. For, he is against government doles and handouts and believes that job creation is the only long-term solution to eradicate poverty. As a sculptor, he wants the state government to encourage genuine artists sans favouritism. He wants the Centre to take better care of this art form. "Things are moving, but at a slow pace," he rues. ■

-Arkamoy Datta Majumdar



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

SIRSHA ACHARYA, 25
Sculptor & painter

Lok Sabha constituency: Baharampur, Bengal

Top 3 demands: Stop minority appeasement, identify and expel corrupt politicians, de-politicise the state police

What will influence his vote: Global respect earned by India, Ram temple, UCC